Lesson 32: Adolescence: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 9.1: Discussion; 9.2: Listening-Debunking Myths about Adolescence; 9.3: Reading-What to Expect from Adolescence; 16.7: Chapter 7 (audio transcript).

In this lesson

This lesson starts the chapter "Adolescence". You will talk about your own teenage years, watch a short video in which a psychology professor, Jenn Pfeifer, corrects three common myths about adolescence, and read an article, "What to Expect from Adolescence", about the intellectual, social, physical and emotional changes of this stage. You will practise questions about main idea, support, audience and cause and effect, which are common in psychology reading.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain the three myths about adolescence in the video and what is actually true.
- Identify the main idea, the audience and the author's way of supporting ideas in an article.
- Describe the four kinds of change in adolescence and how physical and emotional changes are related.
- Talk and write about your own adolescence with examples.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
adolescence; adolescent	the period of life between childhood and adulthood; a young person in this period	It's actually really important for adolescents to take risks.
puberty	the time when a child's body starts to change into an adult's body	Puberty can begin as early as age 8 and as late as 15, depending on the person.
myth	a common belief that is not true	There are a bunch of silly myths about puberty.
debunk	to show that a belief or an idea is false	Debunking Myths about Adolescence
misconception	a wrong idea that many people have	That highlights a third misconception, that parents don't really matter anymore in adolescence.
prefrontal cortex	the front part of the brain; it helps us plan and control our behavior	You can also use your prefrontal cortex to plan how to achieve any kind of goal.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
risk	(the speaker's definition) a decision where the outcome is unknown	A risk is just a decision where the outcome is unknown.
peer	a person of the same age or group as you	... if you're developing differently than your peers, don't worry.
hormone	a chemical in the body that controls growth and other body processes	The hormones in your body can cause mood swings.
mood swing	a sudden change from one feeling to a very different one	Younger teens, or preteens, are more likely to experience stronger mood swings.
growth spurt	a short period when the body grows very fast	One common change is a growth spurt, which can last for 2-3 years.
abstract ideas	ideas about things you cannot see or touch	You begin to think more often about abstract ideas, such as love and beauty.
independent	able to make your own decisions without other people's help	During adolescence, you start to become more independent.
bonkers; chill (informal)	crazy; calm and relaxed	Myths like these are completely bonkers!

Rules and explanations

How to work through this lesson

1. **Discussion:** think about the two questions before you watch (Practice 1).
2. **Listening first:** watch the video (about 4.5 minutes) without the transcript and answer Exercise 1. Then read the transcript at the end of your lesson material to check your answers.
3. **Reading:** read "What to Expect from Adolescence" in your lesson material and answer Exercise 2.

Before you watch

- Jenn Pfeifer is a professor of psychology at the University of Oregon. She studies adolescent development.
- She talks about three myths or misconceptions: about **when** adolescence happens, about the **brain**, and about **parents**. For each one, listen for what people usually believe and what is actually true.

Reading: use the headings and the pronouns

- The article has four headings: INTELLECTUAL, SOCIAL, PHYSICAL and EMOTIONAL. Use them to find information quickly.
- **Audience** means the readers the writer speaks to. Look at the pronouns: the article says *you*, *your* and *we all*. Who is "you"?

- The writer uses informal words (*a bunch of*, *bonkers*, *chill*) because of this audience. Do not use them in academic writing.
- **A relationship question** asks how two things are connected, for example which one causes the other. Look for words like *cause* in the text.

Notice: questions inside sentences

The article puts questions inside sentences, for example: *Why you feel these things can seem like a mystery*. (paragraph 8). The question *Why do you feel these things?* becomes part of the sentence, with no *do* and with statement word order (subject + verb). These are **embedded questions**, the grammar of Lesson 33.

Practice

1. Discussion (before you watch). Answer the questions based on your experience and opinion. Say your answers aloud and record them (1 to 2 minutes each), or discuss them with your tutor.

1. What was your adolescence like? What was your experience as a teenager?
2. What are some changes that teenagers experience?

2. Exercise 1: Listening comprehension. Watch "Debunking Myths about Adolescence" (link in "Watch online"). Watch it first without the transcript. Choose the best answer.

1. When is adolescence?
    - a) Around 10-16 years old
    - b) Around 13 years old
    - c) Around 16 years old
    - d) Around 10-20 years old
2. The second myth is related to brain development. Which statement below is true about adolescence?
    - a) Their brain and body make them do crazy things.
    - b) Their risk-taking is important in their development.
    - c) They cannot process emotions.
    - d) Rewards are hyperresponsive.
3. The third myth is related to parents. What is parents' role in adolescent's development of relationship and social networks?
    - a) Parents can let their adolescents interact with anyone and everyone.
    - b) Parents can limit the adolescent's interaction.
    - c) Parents can help them socialize in a safe and supportive way.
    - d) Parents can invite their adolescents to the parents' circle of friends.

3. Exercise 2: Reading comprehension. Read "What to Expect from Adolescence" in your lesson material (eleven paragraphs). Then answer the questions.

1. Which statement best expresses the main idea in the article?
    - a) It is impossible to understand the reason for the sudden changes in emotions during adolescence.
    - b) All individuals have the same experience and go through the same intellectual, emotional, social and physical changes in adolescence.
    - c) Even though all individuals experience the intellectual, emotional, social and physical changes of adolescence, everyone has a unique experience.
    - d) Adults are essential to really support teenagers through the intellectual, emotional, social and physical changes that they go through during the period of adolescence.
2. How does the author support her ideas about the adolescent experience?
    - a) Smith provides many different examples of the changes that all individuals will go through.
    - b) Smith speaks directly to adolescents to explain how they will all experience changes differently.
    - c) Smith uses scientific data to explain what is happening biologically as individuals go through adolescence.
    - d) Smith speaks to parents to explain how they need to be more patient and understanding with their children as they experience adolescence.
3. Who is the audience of this article, and why does the author speak to this audience directly?
    - a) The author speaks to teenagers to explain what's happening in their bodies.
    - b) The author speaks to teachers to understand how to understand their teenage students.
    - c) The author speaks to parents to explain what's happening in their teenage children's body.
    - d) The author speaks to scientists to help them understand what else to study about adolescence.
4. What is the relationship between the physical and emotional changes that adolescents experience?
    - a) The emotional changes cause the physical changes.
    - b) The physical changes cause the emotional changes.
    - c) The physical changes are minimal compared to the emotional changes.
    - d) The emotional changes are minimal compared to the physical changes.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the two discussion questions from Lesson 32, one at a time, with follow-up questions. At the end, correct my past tenses."
- "I will explain the three myths from Jenn Pfeifer's video and what is actually true. Tell me if I missed or changed anything."
- "Ask me one question about each section of the article: intellectual, social, physical and emotional changes. Then ask me which change I think is the most difficult, and why."

- "Read me a definition from the Key language table of Lesson 32. I will say the word and use it in a sentence about teenagers."
- "Here is my discussion post: [paste]. Check my ideas and examples, then list my grammar errors by type."

Read aloud

The stressed syllable of the long words is in capitals.

1. Ad·o·LES·cence is like a roller coaster: it can be tough, exciting, scary, and fun.
2. PU·ber·ty can begin as early as age 8 and as late as 15, depending on the person.
3. The HOR·mones in your body can cause mood swings.
4. A risk is just a decision where the outcome is unknown.
5. You can also use your pre·FRON·tal COR·tex to plan how to achieve any kind of goal.
6. During adolescence, you start to become more in·de·PEN·dent.

Writing task

In the book, the discussion is a written post for an online class forum. Write your own post on one discussion question from Practice 1 (120 to 180 words).

- Start with a sentence that answers the question directly.
- Give two or three changes or experiences, each with a specific example from your life.
- Connect your answer to the video or the reading at least once, and name your source, for example: *Jenn Pfeifer explains that risk-taking is important for adolescents.*
- Finish with a sentence that sums up your answer.

Self-editing checklist:

1. Does my first sentence answer the question?
2. Did I give a specific example for each change or experience?
3. Did I use the simple past for my own teenage years and the simple present for general facts about teenagers?
4. Did I name the source (the speaker or the article) when I used its ideas?
5. Did I avoid informal words like *bonkers* and *a bunch of*?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it. Then ask your tutor to write two short posts as two classmates, and reply to each one: point out a similarity or a difference, ask a clarifying question, or give your opinion on a point they make.

Watch online

- "Debunking Myths about Adolescence" by Jenn Pfeifer, University of Oregon (about 4.5 minutes): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JoMtQgS6IZU

Answer key

1. Discussion (example answer)

1. My adolescence was exciting but difficult. At about fourteen, I grew very fast and felt strange in my new body. My friends became more important to me than my family, and I wanted to make my own decisions, so I sometimes argued with my parents. I also started to think seriously about my future.
2. Teenagers experience physical changes, such as a growth spurt, voice changes and acne; emotional changes, such as mood swings; social changes, because friends become more important than family; and intellectual changes, because they begin to think about abstract ideas and the future.

2. Exercise 1 (book)

1. d. Adolescence has "a biological beginning with puberty, which can start as early as nine or ten years of age" and "a social end ... typically sometime in your 20s."
2. b. "It's actually really important for adolescents to take risks." (Options a and d repeat the myth and what the media say; option c is not in the video.)
3. c. "If we as parents and as a society can help them do that in safe supportive ways they can all reach their fullest potential."

3. Exercise 2 (book)

1. c. Everyone goes through the four kinds of change (paragraph 3), but at different times and in different ways: "We all have different biological clocks" (paragraph 2).
2. b. The writer speaks to "you" and says that "these changes happen at different times for different people" (paragraph 7).
3. a. The article speaks to young people about their own bodies and feelings, for example "Your body will change in many ways during adolescence" (paragraph 6).
4. b. "The hormones in your body can cause mood swings" (paragraph 8): a physical change causes an emotional change.

My notes